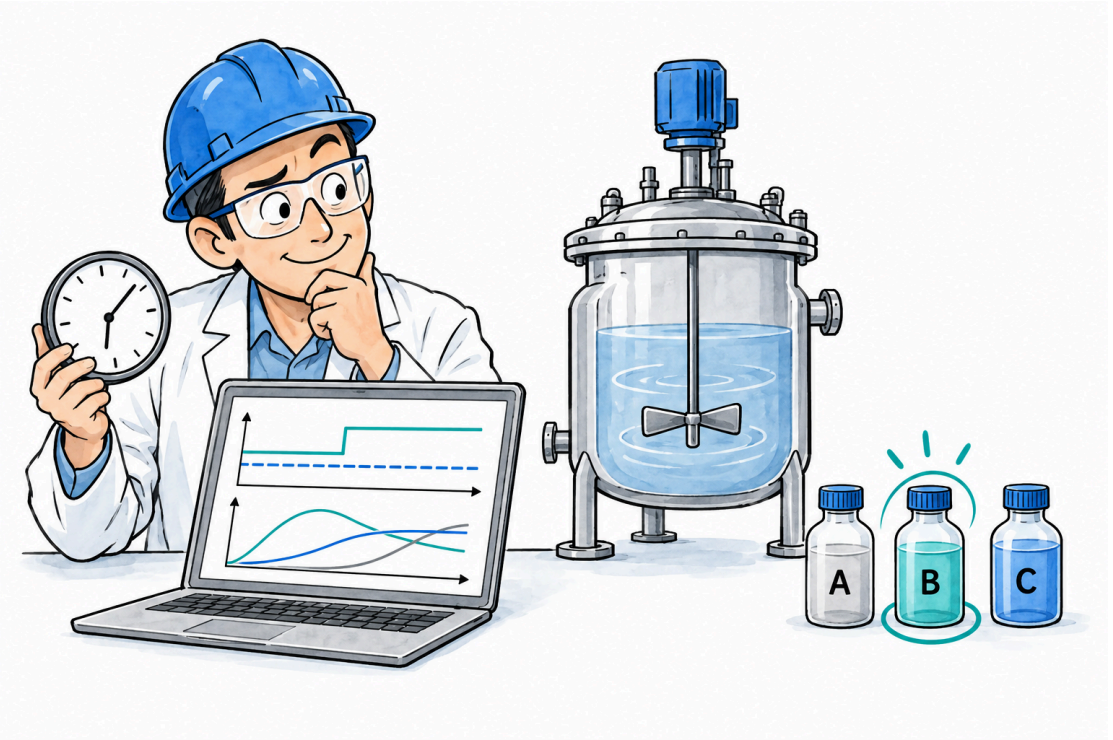
Week 2: Learning Multicomponent Steady-State Responses with MLPs

Conversion and product composition in consecutive reactions

The desired intermediate is B in A → B → C. At short residence time little B forms; at long residence time more B reacts onward to C.

An engineer must predict all three outlet concentrations at each condition because conversion alone does not determine product composition.

Can one model predict A, B, and C consistently?



Componentwise prediction errors

All three concentrations have the same units, but their variation differs. An unscaled loss can emphasize one component.

This week: MLP outputs, one gradient update, and component-wise evaluation.

Learn and check the steady-state MLP

1. Steady-state label derivation for A, B, and C
2. Data scaling, forward pass, backpropagation, and one parameter update
3. MLP training; comparison of component RMSE and concentration-sum residuals

1. A → B → C in a CSTR

Consider a perfectly mixed, constant-volume, constant-density, isothermal CSTR with consecutive first-order reactions A → B → C. The feed contains A; its B and C concentrations are zero. Temperature is an operating input. With concentrations in mol/L, temperature in K, and time in min, the balances are:

$$\frac{dC_A}{dt} = \frac{C_{Af} - C_A}{\tau} - k_1 C_A$$

$$\frac{dC_B}{dt} = -\frac{C_B}{\tau} + k_1 C_A - k_2 C_B$$

$$\frac{dC_C}{dt} = -\frac{C_C}{\tau} + k_2 C_B$$

The B balance contains both formation and consumption. Formation from A contributes $+k_1 C_A$; onward reaction and outflow contribute $-k_2 C_B$ and $-C_B/\tau$. Their competition creates the maximum in B.

Rate constants and operating domain

Both rate constants have units of 1/min. Use the following temperature dependence:

$$k_1\left(T\right) = 0.2\exp\left[6000\left(\frac{1}{330} - \frac{1}{T}\right)\right]$$
$$k_2\left(T\right) = 0.1\exp\left[5000\left(\frac{1}{330} - \frac{1}{T}\right)\right]$$

Quantity	Value or range
Reference temperature	330 K
Reference k_1; k_2	0.2; 0.1 per minute
Temperature-sensitivity parameters	6000 K; 5000 K
Temperature T	300–360 K
Residence time τ	1–10 min
Feed A concentration	0.8–1.5 mol/L

The three balances describe A consumption, B formation and consumption, and C formation. Adding them cancels the reaction terms.

2. Derive the three-output steady-state map

Set the time derivatives to zero and multiply each balance by τ. Collect the concentration terms:

$$\left(1 + k_1\tau\right) C_A = C_{\mathrm{Af}}$$
$$\left(1 + k_2\tau\right) C_B = k_1\tau C_A$$
$$C_C = k_2\tau C_B$$

The first equation contains only A, so solve it directly. Substitute A into the second equation for B, then B into the last equation for C. This ordering avoids an iterative simultaneous solve for all three unknowns.

Solve for A, B, and C

Solve in the order A, B, C:

$$C_A = \frac{C_{\mathrm{Af}}}{1 + k_1\tau}$$

$$C_B = \frac{k_1\tau C_{\mathrm{Af}}}{(1 + k_1\tau)(1 + k_2\tau)}$$

$$C_C = k_2\tau C_B$$

At 330 K, τ = 5 min, and feed = 1.2 mol/L, the concentrations are [0.6, 0.4, 0.2] mol/L. Their sum equals the feed concentration. These three outputs are the labels for the steady-state MLP.

Numerically, A=1.2/2=0.6, B=(0.2×5×0.6)/1.5=0.4, then C=0.1×5×0.4=0.2. The B denominator must retain both the outflow term 1 and the onward-reaction term 0.5.

Nonmonotone response of intermediate B

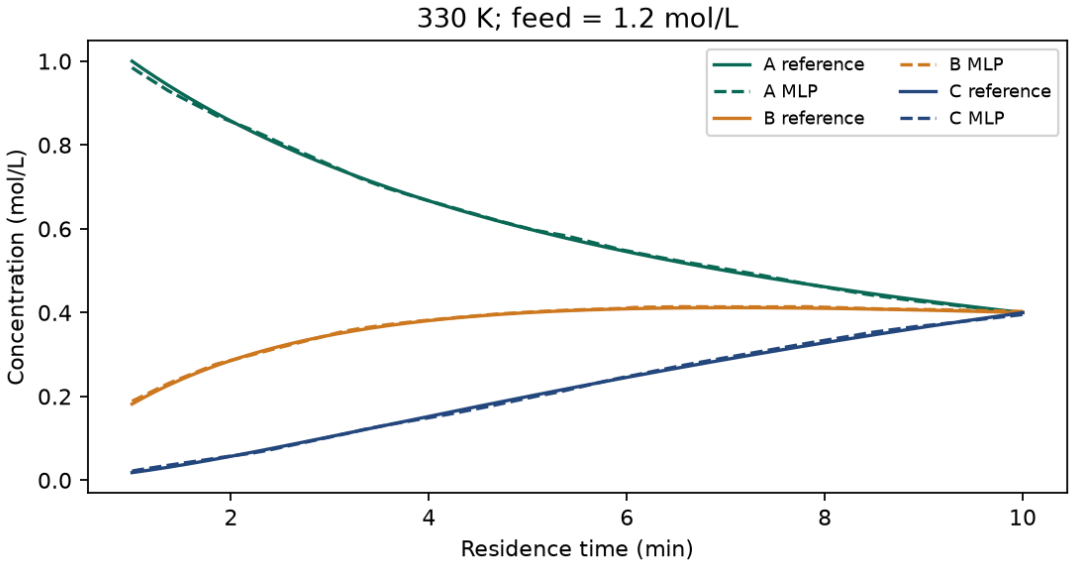
At a fixed temperature, the B yield and its maximizing residence time follow from the expression for C_B:

$$Y_B = \frac{C_B}{C_{\mathrm{Af}}} = \frac{k_1\tau}{\left(1+k_1\tau\right)\left(1+k_2\tau\right)}, \quad \tau^* = \frac{1}{\sqrt{k_1 k_2}}$$

Write the denominator as $D=1+(k_1+k_2)\tau+k_1k_2\tau^2$. Differentiation gives numerator $k_1(D-\tau D')=k_1(1-k_1k_2\tau^2)$. The positive denominator D^2 does not change its sign: yield increases before $\tau=1/\sqrt{(k_1k_2)}$ and decreases afterward.

Compare the three concentration profiles

At 330 K, τ* is about 7.07 min. Short residence times limit B formation; long residence times allow more B to react to C.



Three-component response at 330 K. The B concentration has an interior maximum.

3. Prepare the supervised dataset

Each row contains inputs [T, τ, C_Af] and outputs [C_A, C_B, C_C]. Input and output arrays both have shape (N, 3). Generate 400 train, 120 validation, and 160 test operating points within the table's bounds, then calculate their labels with the steady-state map.

The three concentrations have the same units but different variations. In the training data, their standard deviations are approximately [0.283, 0.110, 0.217] mol/L.

A, B, and C in one row belong to the same input. Shuffling components independently breaks input-label alignment. Apply splitting and shuffling to paired input and output rows.

4. Forward calculation and scaling

MLP architecture: 3 → 32 → 32 → 3; ReLU hidden layers and a linear output layer.

Hidden-layer calculation: weighted sum + bias → ReLU(a) = max(0, a). Positive values retained; negative values set to zero. Parameters fitted to concentration data: weights and biases.

$$h_1 = \mathrm{ReLU}\left(W_1 \tilde{\mathrm{x}} + b_1\right)$$
$$h_2 = \mathrm{ReLU}\left(W_2 h_1 + b_2\right)$$
$$\hat{z} = W_3 h_2 + b_3$$

Layer	Weight shape	Bias shape	Parameters
Input → hidden 1	32 × 3	32	128
Hidden 1 → hidden 2	32 × 32	32	1056
Hidden 2 → output	3 × 32	3	99
Total			**1283**

One neuron combines all input columns into one number. Each of 32 first-layer neurons has three weights and one bias, giving 32×(3+1)=128 parameters. Hidden layers repeat this computation for several learned features.

Scaling and the training loss

Scale the inputs with the declared lower and upper bounds. Standardize each output with its training mean μ and standard deviation s, and restore physical units after prediction:

$$\tilde{x}_j = 2\frac{x_j - l_j}{u_j - l_j} - 1$$

$$z_j = \frac{y_j - \mu_j}{s_j}, \quad \hat{y}_j = \mu_j + s_j \hat{z}_j$$

Loss: mean squared error across samples and standardized output components.

$$L = \frac{1}{3N} \sum_{n=1}^{N} \sum_{j=1}^{3} \left(\hat{z}_{n,j} - z_{n,j} \right)^2$$

Thus a concentration error is measured relative to that component's training variation. For example, the smaller B standard deviation gives its raw squared error a larger weight in this loss.

The same 0.01 mol/L error becomes about 0.0353 for A and 0.0909 for B after division by 0.283 and 0.110. Squaring makes B contribute about 6.62 times as much. Output scaling changes the relative emphasis in training as well as the numerical scale.

5. Backpropagation: one calculation

Calculation example: a 3 → 2 → 3 network with zero biases and the values below. Loss: $L = \frac{1}{2}\|\hat{y} - y\|^2$. Learning rate: 0.1.

$$x = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ -1 \end{bmatrix}, y = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$W_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, W_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Hidden pre-activation a, activation h, prediction, and error:

$$a = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{bmatrix}, h = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \hat{y} = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}, e = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

The first hidden neuron reads input component 1 and the second reads component −1. ReLU leaves [1,0]. The output layer forms [first, second, their sum], yielding [1,0,1].

Gradients and the parameter update

The output error propagates through the output weights and the ReLU derivative:

$$\delta_2 = e, \nabla_{W_2} L = eh^T = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\delta_1 = \left({W_2}^T e \right) \odot \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 2 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\nabla_{W_1} L = \delta_1 x^T = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 0 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

The bias gradients are δ_1 and δ_2. Update every weight and bias with parameter ← parameter − 0.1 × gradient. The next forward calculation gives [0.26, 0.14, 0.26], and the loss decreases from 1.5 to 0.4374. The notebook checks these gradients using autograd.

The first hidden value connects to outputs A and C with unit weights, receiving their combined error 1+1=2. The second pre-activation is negative, so its ReLU derivative is zero. Its input weights and bias therefore do not move in this update.

The second forward pass after updating parameters

Update both weights and biases with learning rate 0.1. Subtracting $0.1\times[2,0,-2]$ from the first hidden weight $[1,0,0]$ gives $[0.8,0,0.2]$; its bias becomes -0.2.

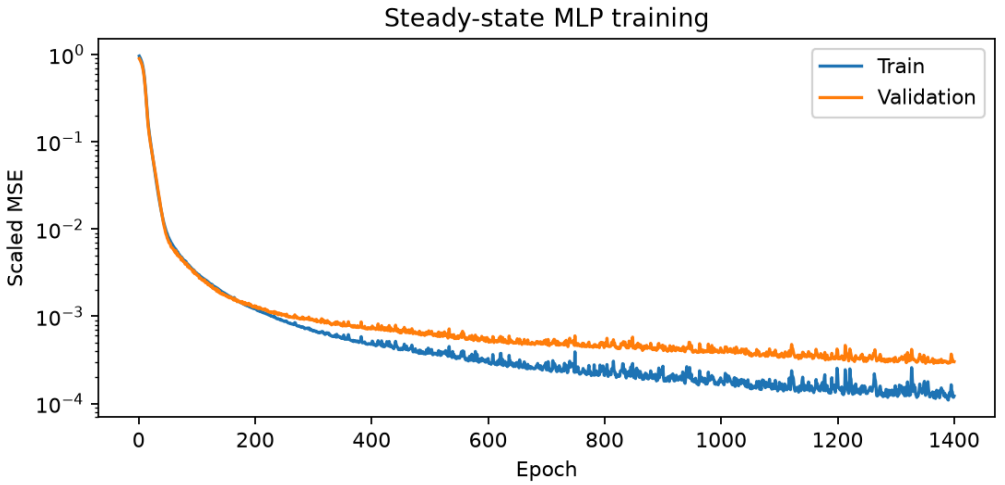
Intermediate value	Updated calculation
First hidden pre-activation	$0.8\times1+0\times0+0.2\times(-1)-0.2=0.4$
Second hidden pre-activation	-1
ReLU output	$[0.4,0]$
Outputs A and C	$0.9\times0.4-0.1=0.26$
Output B	$0.1\times0.4+0.1=0.14$

The new error is $[0.26,-0.86,0.26]$. Loss falls to $(0.0676+0.7396+0.0676)/2=0.4374$, but B remains below its target 1. One decrease does not complete training.

6. Train and evaluate the steady-state model

Training: Adam, learning rate 0.001, batch size 64, up to 1400 epochs. Weight selection: minimum validation loss across epochs.

```
prediction = model(inputs)
loss = loss_function(prediction, targets)
optimizer.zero_grad()
loss.backward()
optimizer.step()
```



Training and validation loss. Prediction metrics below are computed after restoring mol/L units.

Values and changes inside the training loop

```
prediction = model(inputs)
loss = loss_function(prediction, targets)
optimizer.zero_grad()
loss.backward()
optimizer.step()
```

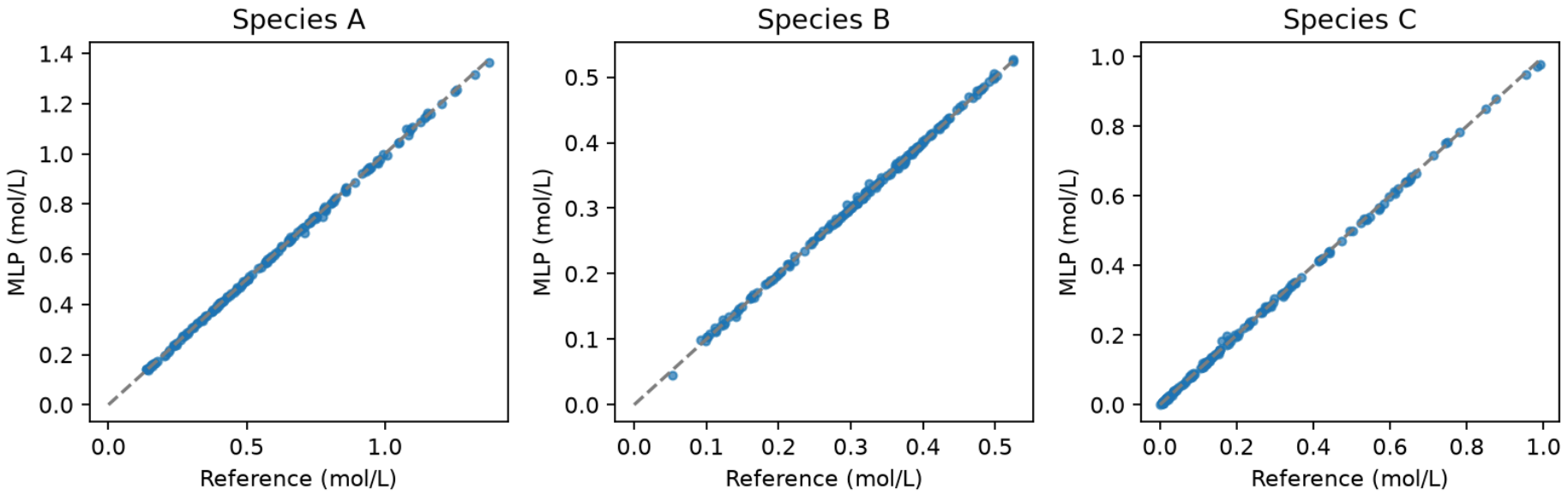
Line	Value produced or changed
model(inputs)	Batch predictions with current weights
loss_function	Prediction errors reduced to a scalar loss
zero_grad	Previous batch gradients cleared
backward	Current loss gradients for weights and biases
step	Parameters updated using gradients and optimizer state

The hand calculation uses gradient descent; the lab uses Adam. Adam also uses gradient history, so its numerical update is not the same subtraction by 0.1 times the gradient. To assess the updated parameters, run a new forward pass after step.

Evaluate each output component

Test RMSE, mol/L	A	B	C
Output scaling	0.005275	0.002940	0.004423
Unscaled outputs	0.006634	0.003917	0.004162

In this comparison, output scaling reduces A and B RMSE; C RMSE is slightly higher. Evaluate each component rather than combining all three into one error number.



Separate parity plots reveal each component's errors.

From standardized outputs to concentrations and errors

For a one-component calculation, take training mean μ=0.4 mol/L and standard deviation s=0.1 mol/L. Target concentration 0.45 becomes z=(0.45−0.4)/0.1=0.5.

Quantity	Calculation
Standardized network prediction	$\hat{z}=0.3$
Restore concentration	0.4+0.1×0.3=0.43 mol/L
Standardized error	0.3−0.5=−0.2
Concentration error	0.43−0.45=−0.02 mol/L

```
prediction = y_mean + y_scale * standardized_prediction
component_rmse = np.sqrt(((prediction - truth)**2).mean(axis=0))
sum_residual = prediction.sum(axis=1) - feed
```

The first line applies each column’s mean and scale. axis=0 measures accuracy by component; axis=1 sums the three components at one condition. Swapping these axes computes a different quantity.

Check the concentration sum

$$r = \hat{C}_A + \hat{C}_B + \hat{C}_C - C_{\mathrm{Af}}$$

Its test RMSE is 0.003781 mol/L. Component prediction errors and the residual describe different aspects of the model.

Balance-consistent training labels do not force the sum of the three linear outputs to match the feed concentration.

For feed 1.2 mol/L, predictions [0.62, 0.41, 0.20] mol/L sum to 1.23 mol/L, giving r = 0.03 mol/L. A model predicting mole fractions can likewise return a sum different from one.

The sum residual equals the sum of component errors. Errors [0.02,−0.01,−0.01] sum to zero despite incorrect components. Small positive errors in all three components instead accumulate into a larger total-concentration error.

Week 4 preview: concentration-sum constraints in the model

We can correct a prediction after training, or include a constraint-respecting transformation in the training calculation.

Approach	Where the correction enters
Post-training mapping/projection	Train the raw predictor, then correct its outputs.
KKT-hPINN	Apply a fixed affine projection using the input and raw prediction before the loss, and at inference.

$$x \rightarrow f_\theta \rightarrow \hat{y} \rightarrow \Pi_x \rightarrow \tilde{y} \rightarrow \text{loss}$$

KKT-hPINN computes the loss on projected outputs and backpropagates through the projection layer. Projection coefficients stay fixed while the MLP weights learn with the transformation in place.

The projection layer satisfies the specified linear equalities up to numerical arithmetic; nonnegativity needs an additional constraint.

Source: Chen et al. (2024), DOI: 10.1016/j.compchemeng.2024.108764.

7. Run the required steady-state lab

Download the steady-state notebook.

```
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
python week02_lab.py --mode steady --output-dir week02-results
```

Evaluate the trained predictor by component RMSE and concentration-sum residual.

8. Core exercises and submission

1. Derive C_A, C_B, and C_C and verify their sum. Explain the nonmonotone B curve.
2. Count the 1283 steady-state MLP parameters and verify the hand-calculated gradient update.
3. Compare scaled and unscaled outputs by each component’s RMSE.
4. Inspect concentration-sum residual and minimum predicted concentration on held-out inputs.

Submission: steady-state model, split/scaling details, checked gradient update, and component/consistency evaluation.

Original explanations: PyTorch model construction, autograd, and training.

Reading companion

Week 2 companion · English PDF

KKT-hPINN reference: Chen, H., Constante Flores, G. E., & Li, C. (2024). Physics-informed neural networks with hard linear equality constraints. *Computers & Chemical Engineering*, 189, 108764.